

NinaivX — Ethics & Voice Licensing Statement

Why this project requires no ethical approval · Ashwin Kumar Ramesh Kumar · MSc AI, University of Sheffield

1. Purpose

This statement sets out why the NinaivX project, as built and evaluated for this dissertation, does **not require ethical approval**, and why its use of synthesised voices raises **no copyright or consent concerns**. It covers the persona data, the voices used, and the voice-cloning demonstration.

2. What triggers ethical approval

Ethical approval (and data-protection duties) are triggered by **collecting or using data from real, identifiable people** — for example interviews, surveys or user studies with human participants, or the use of a real person's **personal or biometric data** (a real individual's voice is biometric data). Where a project involves **no human participants and no real personal data**, ethical approval is generally not required.

3. How NinaivX avoids it — a synthetic-only design

Every element of the build and evaluation uses **fictional, self-authored (synthetic) data** and **synthetic voices**. No real, identifiable person's data is collected, stored or processed.

Activity in the project	Real, identifiable person?	Personal / biometric data?	Ethical approval	Copyright / consent
Personas (fictional characters authored by the developer)	No	No	Not required	Not applicable
ElevenLabs <i>listed</i> (default) voices used for speech	No	No	Not required	Licensed under ElevenLabs' Terms of Service
Voice cloning demonstrated on an AI-generated sample	No	No	Not required	Sample generated via the developer's own licensed account
Technical evaluation (fabrication test) on synthetic personas	No	No	Not required	Not applicable

4. Voices — licensing

The voices used for speech synthesis are ElevenLabs' **default (listed) voices**. These are synthetic or professionally-licensed voices for which **ElevenLabs holds the rights**; generated audio is

used under ElevenLabs' Terms of Service through the developer's own account. They are **not recordings of, and do not identify, any real individual**, so they involve no personal data and require no separate copyright clearance for this academic, non-commercial use.

5. Voice cloning — demonstrated with synthetic samples only

The application includes a voice-cloning feature (upload a recording → clone → assign to a persona). For the demonstration and evaluation this is exercised **only on AI-generated (synthetic) voice samples** — for example a clip produced by the project's own text-to-speech via GET /api/synthetic-voice. Because the cloned sample is **not a real person** and is generated through the developer's own licensed account, this raises **no consent, copyright or ethics issue**. Male and female synthetic samples are provided in the app for this purpose.

6. Explicitly out of scope (would require approval)

The following are **not** performed in this dissertation, and would each require ethical approval and, where relevant, consent and licensing:

- Cloning the voice of a **real, identifiable person** (living or deceased) — a real voice is biometric personal data. **Requires approval + consent.**
- Any **study with real participants** (interviews, questionnaires, usability testing). **Requires approval.**
- Collecting or processing **real users' personal data**. **Requires approval.**

7. Declaration

The NinaivX build and evaluation use only **fictional (synthetic) personas** and **synthetic voices**. There are **no human participants** and **no real personal or biometric data**. The voices are ElevenLabs' licensed default voices, and voice cloning is demonstrated solely on AI-generated samples. On this basis, the project **does not require ethical approval**, and its voice use raises **no copyright or consent concerns**.

Note: this statement records the student's justification for the scope described above. The final determination of whether ethical approval is required rests with the University of Sheffield's ethics review process, and voice-tool usage is subject to ElevenLabs' current Terms of Service. This document is not legal advice. If the project scope later changes to involve any real person's data, ethical approval must be sought before proceeding.